XAI preferences of financial professionals

Welcome!
Thank you for considering participation. This survey is part of the IRP-9 MSCA project at the University of Naples Federico II (UNINA). Our aim is to understand how finance professionals perceive and prefer different types of AI explanations, tailored to their roles and responsibilities.

What Participation Involves
You will be asked about your professional role, tasks, experience with AI, and preferences for explanation formats under various decision-making contexts.
Estimated time: **10–15 minutes.** There are no right or wrong answers; your honest input is valuable.

Voluntary Participation & Withdrawal
Your participation is completely voluntary. You may skip any question or stop at any time. If you withdraw before submitting, your responses will not be recorded.

Data Use, Confidentiality & UNINA Privacy Summary

- Your responses will be anonymized and stored in aggregate form; no names or personal identifiers will be published.
- Data will be stored securely on systems compliant with EU and UNINA data protection regulations.
- The University of Naples Federico II, in the persons of the Rector and the General Director, in relation to the specific legislative and regulatory provisions, is the Data Controller of all processing of personal data, also for the particular categories of data pursuant to art. 9 and criminal convictions and crimes pursuant to art. 10 of GDPR 679/2016.
    - The registered office of the University is in Corso Umberto I n. 40 - 80138 Naples.
    - **Email**: rettore@unina.it

- UNINA follows technical and organizational privacy measures consistent with institutional policy to protect your data and ensure transparency.

Risks & Benefits

No direct risks or monetary compensation are associated with participation. Your input will contribute to developing more transparent and trustworthy AI systems in finance, benefiting industry, regulation, and society.

Ethics Statement

This study was reviewed and approved by the *Comitato Etico per la Ricerca con Soggetti Umani in Campo non Biomedico* (CERSUB, University of Naples Federico II; Ethics Committee for Research with Human Subjects in Non-Biomedical Fields) on September 25, 2025 with reference number PG/2025/0133225.

* Required

Welcome

Consent
By proceeding to the next page, you confirm that:

- You have read and understood this information;
- You are 18 or older and currently or formerly employed in a finance-related role;
- You voluntarily consent to participate in this research under these conditions.

*

- ◯ Yes
- ◯ No

Job Title

What is your current job level in your organization? *

- ◯ Intern / Trainee
- ◯ Financial Analyst / Associate
- ◯ Senior Analyst / Associate
- ◯ Vice President or Manager (e.g. Team Lead or Unit Head)
- ◯ Director
- ◯ Managing Director or Executive (e.g. C-Suite or Group Head)
- ◯ Other

How would you categorize your affiliation?

- ◯ Academic institution or think tank related to finance
- ◯ Central banking
- ◯ Companies auxiliary to financial services (consulting, AI services vendor and other outsourced business process)
- ◯ Credit institutions
- ◯ Credit union, cooperative or similar non-for-profit financial institution
- ◯ Deposit-receiving financial intermediaries other than credit institutions (EXCEPT neobanks)
- ◯ Insurance corporations (life and non-life and reinsurance)
- ◯ Local government financing or other public institution
- ◯ Money market funds
- ◯ Neobanks
- ◯ Investment fund management except solely cryptocurrencies
- ◯ Payment service providers including remittance centers and electronic money institutions
- ◯ Pension funding, retirement, and employee benefit plans

- ◯ Peer-to-peer lending and virtual currencies (e.g., cryptocurrencies)
- ◯ Regulatory, supervisory or audit body
- ◯ Security brokerage and other financial vehicle corporations
- ◯ Independent wealth or financial advisor
- ◯ Other

In your job, who do you mainly provide output or reports to? *

- ☐ Executive management (e.g., board or senior leadership)
- ☐ Corporate customers (business clients)
- ☐ Private individuals (retail clients or consumers)
- ☐ Internal auditors or compliance teams
- ☐ Regulatory or supervisory bodies
- ☐ Other

You and Artificial Intelligence

What types of data do you use or encounter at work?

- [ ] Personal data with legal bases (customer demographic data, identities)
- [ ] Transactional data from customer actions or product data
- [ ] Behavioral or usage in websites or apps
- [ ] High frequency data (e.g., trading data)
- [ ] Financial statements or accounting data
- [ ] Pre-processed or aggregated data (e.g., ratios, derived features)
- [ ] Semi-structured text data like free text, reports
- [ ] External market data (e.g., macroeconomic indicators, news sentiment)
- [ ] Documents stores in PDF or similar format
- [ ] Images
- [ ] Other

I am aware...

	1 - Not at all familiar	2 - Slightly familiar	3 - Fairly familiar	4 - Familiar	5 - Very f
...that there are so-called "black box" models in finance, whose decision-making processes are difficult to understand.	○	○	○	○	○
...that the most accurate AI systems often fail to clearly explain their decisions.	○	○	○	○	○
...of the difference between intrinsically interpretable AI systems and those that only provide approximate explanations after making a decision.	○	○	○	○	○

Which statement best describes your current AI skills? *

- [ ] I have no formal training or experience with AI.
- [ ] I can understand AI concepts and recognize when AI is being used
- [ ] I can operate or interact with AI-based systems
- [ ] I can read, summarize, and draw conclusions from AI model's results
- [ ] I can evaluate AI systems critically (with respect to fairness, explainability, accuracy, responsible/safe AI standards, etc.)
- [ ] I can design, build, or customize models and explanation methods.

What AI systems do you use at work?

- [ ] Computer vision or image detection (e.g., Know-Your-Customer (KYC) verification)
- [ ] Natural Language Processing (e.g., Reading and extracting data from contracts or documents or news screening)
- [ ] Machine Learning or learning patterns from historical data (e.g., predictive models like credit or risk scoring)
- [ ] Anomaly detection or outlier detection (e.g., flags for suspiscious transactions)
- [ ] Agentic AI or autonomous systems that have limited human intervention
- [ ] Generative AI (e.g., GPT tools, AI-generated text or reports)
- [ ] Retrieval-Augemented Generation (RAG) - Checking internal data before answering
- [ ] Recommendation Systems (e.g., product or investment suggestions based on user data)
- [ ] We don't use AI / Not applicable
- [ ] Other

What is your role in these AI systems? *

- [ ] Creator or Developer - I build, design or train the system/model.
- [ ] Model Validator - I make sure the model is of sufficient quality
- [ ] Technical Manager - I am responsible for the application
- [ ] Operator - I interact with the system directly (e.g., run queries, use dashboards, monitor outputs).
- [ ] Executor - I make decisions based on the system's outputs
- [ ] Conduct regulator - I ensure the models are consistent with conduct rules (e.g., consumer protection, fair lending).
- [ ] Prudential regulator - I ensure that models comply with prudential requirements (e.g., adequacy, risk weighted assets, liquidity, systemic risk, etc.)
- [ ] AI Solutions Consultant – I explain the system’s capabilities and technical logic to clients and internal teams, helping them evaluate and adopt the model.
- [ ] Not applicable
- [ ] Other

What forms of explanation, if any, do you currently receive from the AI systems you use?

- [ ] We do not currently receive formal explanations.
- [ ] SHAP values or feature importance maps (e.g., top contributing variables, ranked factors)
- [ ] LIME or local surrogate explanations (e.g., simplified local model for one prediction)
- [ ] Risk scores, probabilities, or model confidence (e.g., fraud score, credit risk score)
- [ ] Charts, dashboards, or visual analytics (e.g., graphs, plots, monitoring dashboards)
- [ ] Rule-based explanations (e.g., "This transaction was flagged because it exceeds threshold X")
- [ ] Business narrative explanations (simple text summaries: "Approved because the balance is sufficient")
- [ ] Source citations or retrieved documents (RAG) (e.g., references to policies, guidelines, or PDFs used to generate the answer)
- [ ] Training materials or user guides that explain how the model works (e.g., onboarding slide decks, written documentation)
- [ ] Model documentation / methodological notes (e.g., overview of variables, model architecture, validation summary)
- [ ] Other

How satisfied are you with the AI explanations you currently receive?

Not at all satisfied ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆ Completely satisfied

What makes a good explanation?

In your day-to-day work, which type of explanation would be more valuable to you?

- ◯ One that explains specific outcomes (e.g., for one decision or client)
- ◯ One that summarizes overall drivers or "the big picture"
- ◯ Both matter equally
- ◯ I tend to need broader summaries
- ◯ I tend to need specific case details
- ◯ Not applicable

In your role, how important are the following **qualities** of an explanation? *

	1 - Not important at all	2 - Slightly important	3 - Moderately important	4 - Important	5 - Extremely important	DON'T
Help me make decisions	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Easy to understand	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Meets regulatory requirements	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Presented like talking to a person	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Visual-ready	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Fits my situation or task	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Lets me explore or adjust	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Aligns with my expertise or theory	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯

In your role, how much do the following **technical** aspects of an explanation matter? *

	1 - Not at all important	2 - Slightly important	3 - Moderately important	4 - Important	5 - Extremely important	DON'T
How fast explanations are produced	○	○	○	○	○	(
Shows how confident the model is in its result	○	○	○	○	○	(
Works well across different cases or datasets	○	○	○	○	○	(
Compatible with other software or models	○	○	○	○	○	(
Still makes sense even when inputs slighly change	○	○	○	○	○	(

	1 - Not at all important	2 - Slightly important	3 - Moderately important	4 - Important	5 - Extremely important	DON'T
Reflects the model's true reasoning behind predictions	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Provides the possible consequences if the AI system makes an error	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯

XAI Model Features

It is useful for me if explanations show... *

	1 - Not at all useful	2 - Slightly useful	3 - Moderately useful	4 - Useful	5 - Extremely useful	DON'T
What could be changed in the input to get a different prediction *(counterfactual explanations)*	○	○	○	○	○	○
The sequence of rules activated in the model's making process *(rule-based logic)*	○	○	○	○	○	○
List all possible reasons for a prediction	○	○	○	○	○	○
Only the most important reasons for a prediction *(feature importance)*	○	○	○	○	○	○

	1 - Not at all useful	2 - Slightly useful	3 - Moderately useful	4 - Useful	5 - Extremely useful	DON'T
Something to tell me when a result is meaningful or just a false alarm	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯

Which analytical details are useful for your role? *

	1 - Not at all useful	2 - Slightly useful	3 - Moderately useful	4 - Useful	5 - Extremely useful	DON'T
Whether results truly came from the data provided *(data provenance)*	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
How two or more factors interact together in affecting the results and not just each factor alone *(feature interactions)*	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Numerical weights or coefficients that directly link inputs to outputs	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Patterns in the data even if they don't match known financial indicators	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯

Demography

Gender *

- ◯ Male
- ◯ Female
- ◯ Non-binary
- ◯ Prefer not to say

Country *

- Afghanistan
- Albania
- Algeria
- Andorra
- Angola
- Antigua and Barbuda
- Argentina
- Armenia
- Australia
- Austria
- Azerbaijan
- Bahamas
- Bahrain

- ◯ Bangladesh
- ◯ Barbados
- ◯ Belarus
- ◯ Belgium
- ◯ Belize
- ◯ Benin
- ◯ Bhutan
- ◯ Bolivia
- ◯ Bosnia and Herzegovina
- ◯ Botswana
- ◯ Brazil
- ◯ Brunei Darussalam
- ◯ Bulgaria
- ◯ Burkina Faso

- ◯ Burundi
- ◯ Cambodia
- ◯ Cameroon
- ◯ Canada
- ◯ Cape Verde
- ◯ Central African Republic
- ◯ Chad
- ◯ Chile
- ◯ China
- ◯ Colombia
- ◯ Comoros
- ◯ Congo (Republic)
- ◯ Congo (Democratic Republic)
- ◯ Costa Rica

- Croatia
- Cuba
- Cyprus
- Czech Republic
- Denmark
- Djibouti
- Dominica
- Dominican Republic
- Ecuador
- Egypt
- El Salvador
- Equatorial Guinea
- Eritrea
- Estonia

- Eswatini
- Ethiopia
- Fiji
- Finland
- France
- Gabon
- Gambia
- Georgia
- Germany
- Ghana
- Greece
- Grenada
- Guatemala
- Guinea

- ◯ Guinea-Bissau
- ◯ Guyana
- ◯ Haiti
- ◯ Honduras
- ◯ Hungary
- ◯ Iceland
- ◯ India
- ◯ Indonesia
- ◯ Iran
- ◯ Iraq
- ◯ Ireland
- ◯ Israel
- ◯ Italy
- ◯ Jamaica

- Japan
- Jordan
- Kazakhstan
- Kenya
- Kiribati
- Kuwait
- Kyrgyzstan
- Laos
- Latvia
- Lebanon
- Lesotho
- Liberia
- Libya
- Liechtenstein

- Lithuania
- Luxembourg
- Madagascar
- Malawi
- Malaysia
- Maldives
- Mali
- Malta
- Marshall Islands
- Mauritania
- Mauritius
- Mexico
- Micronesia
- Moldova

- ◯ Monaco
- ◯ Mongolia
- ◯ Montenegro
- ◯ Morocco
- ◯ Mozambique
- ◯ Myanmar
- ◯ Namibia
- ◯ Nauru
- ◯ Nepal
- ◯ Netherlands
- ◯ New Zealand
- ◯ Nicaragua
- ◯ Niger
- ◯ Nigeria

- North Korea
- North Macedonia
- Norway
- Oman
- Pakistan
- Palau
- Palestine
- Panama
- Papua New Guinea
- Paraguay
- Peru
- Philippines
- Poland
- Portugal

- ◯ Qatar
- ◯ Romania
- ◯ Russia
- ◯ Rwanda
- ◯ Saint Kitts and Nevis
- ◯ Saint Lucia
- ◯ Saint Vincent and the Grenadines
- ◯ Samoa
- ◯ San Marino
- ◯ Sao Tome and Principe
- ◯ Saudi Arabia
- ◯ Senegal
- ◯ Serbia
- ◯ Seychelles

- ◯ Sierra Leone
- ◯ Singapore
- ◯ Slovakia
- ◯ Slovenia
- ◯ Solomon Islands
- ◯ Somalia
- ◯ South Africa
- ◯ South Korea
- ◯ South Sudan
- ◯ Spain
- ◯ Sri Lanka
- ◯ Sudan
- ◯ Suriname

- Switzerland
- Syria
- Taiwan
- Tajikistan
- Tanzania
- Thailand
- Timor-Leste
- Togo
- Tonga
- Trinidad and Tobago
- Tunisia
- Turkey
- Turkmenistan

- ◯ Uganda
- ◯ Ukraine
- ◯ United Arab Emirates
- ◯ United Kingdom
- ◯ United States of America
- ◯ Uruguay
- ◯ Uzbekistan
- ◯ Vanuatu
- ◯ Vatican City
- ◯ Venezuela
- ◯ Vietnam
- ◯ Yemen
- ◯ Zambia

Age *

- ◯ 18-24
- ◯ 25-34
- ◯ 35-44
- ◯ 45-54
- ◯ 55-64
- ◯ 65+

Highest level of education attained *

- ◯ No formal education
- ◯ Primary school
- ◯ Lower secondary school or middle school
- ◯ Upper secondary school or high school
- ◯ University-level education (e.g., bachelor's degree or higher-level vocational training)
- ◯ Post-graduate education or equivalent (e.g. PhD or advanced professional training)

Field of Study *

If you completed studies in several disciplines, please select the field where you spent the most years or received your highest qualification or professional training.

- ◯ Agricultural, Food, and Forestry Sciences
- ◯ Animal and Veterinary Sciences
- ◯ Architecture and Urban Planning
- ◯ Arts, Music, Design, and Fashion
- ◯ Biological and Life Sciences
- ◯ Biotechnology
- ◯ Business, Economics, and Management
- ◯ Chemical and Physical Sciences
- ◯ Civil, Industrial, and Environmental Engineering
- ◯ Communication and Media Studies
- ◯ Computer and Information Sciences
- ◯ Cultural Heritage and History

- ◯ Education and Training
- ◯ Geography and Environmental Sciences
- ◯ Law and Legal Studies
- ◯ Mathematics and Statistics
- ◯ Philosophy and Humanities
- ◯ Political and Social Sciences
- ◯ Psychology
- ◯ Tourism and Service Management
- ◯ Other

Years in finance *

- ◯ <3 years
- ◯ 3-10 years
- ◯ More than 10 years
- ◯ This does not apply to me

What are your thoughts on the current and future use of explainable AI (XAI) in the industry?

For example: Is it being used effectively? Should it be used more? What's working well or not?

If you want to be informed of the survey results or progress of this research, feel free to leave your email below.

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